ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

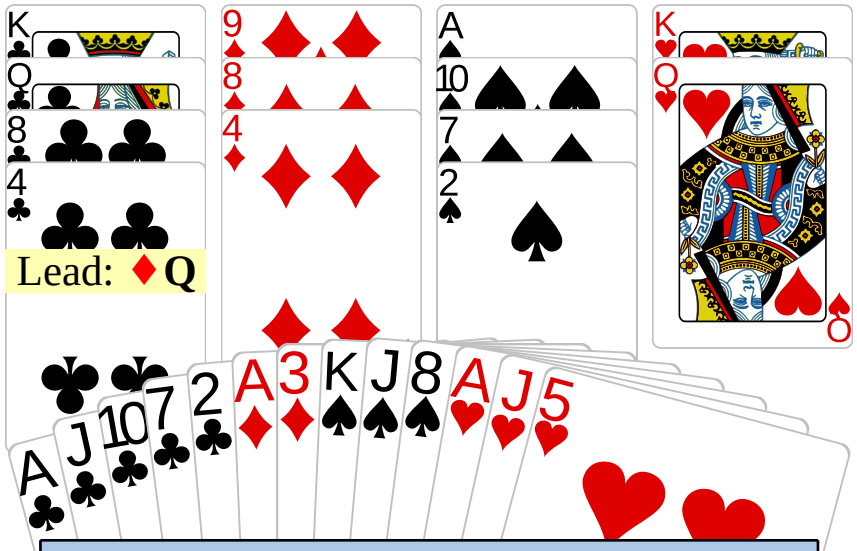
These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



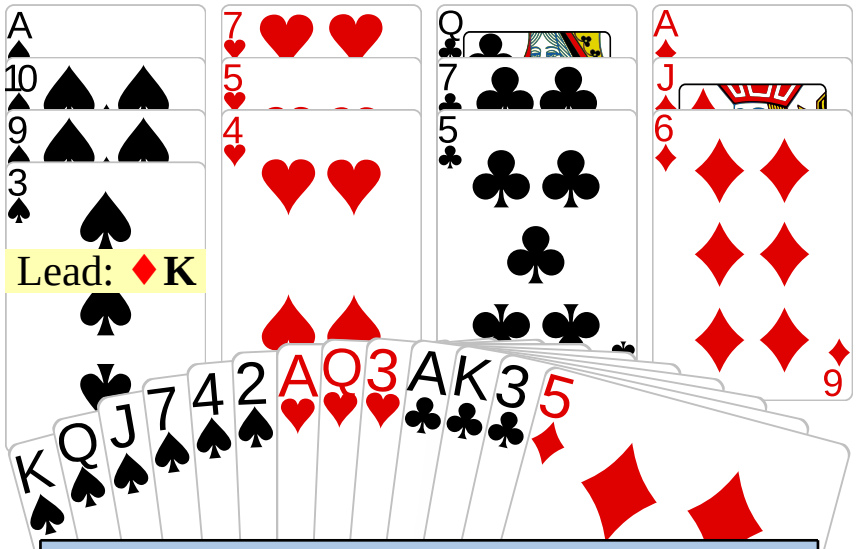
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



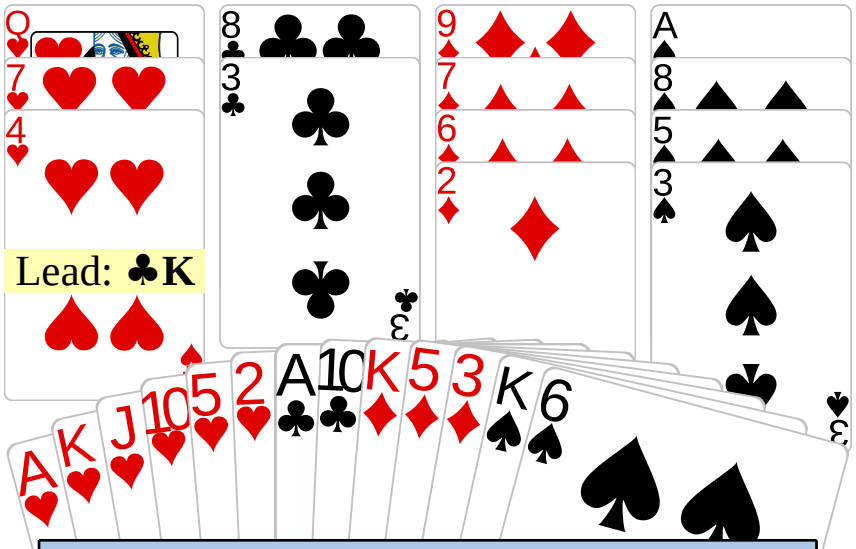
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



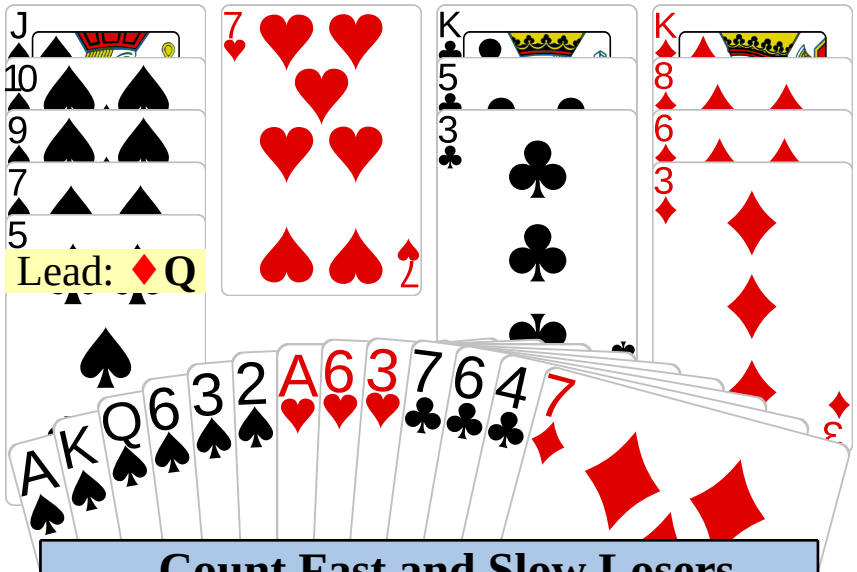
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥K

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦K

Board: 4
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 8 ♥ A J 5 ♦ A 3 ♣ A J 10 7 2	
♠ Q 4 3 ♥ 10 7 6 2 ♦ J 7 6 ♣ 9 5 3	N W E S	♠ 9 6 5 ♥ 9 8 4 3 ♦ K Q 10 5 2 ♣ 6
	♠ A 10 7 2 ♥ K Q ♦ 9 8 4 ♣ K Q 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	4♣
Pass	6♣		
All Pass			

6♣ by North
Lead: ♦Q

The slam was easy to bid, now you just have to make it. North plays 6♣. East leads the ♦Q.

You have one certain ♦ loser, and a two-way finesse for the ♠Q. That should make you start thinking about elimination and throw-in. So win the ♦A and pull trumps, East having a singleton.

You eliminate the ♥s: the ♥K, the ♥Q overtaken by your ♥A, then the ♥J.

BE CAREFUL! On the ♥J you must discard a ♦ from dummy so both of you will be out of ♦s at the throw-in.

NOW you can execute the throw-in. Play your ♦, which eliminates ♦s from both you and dummy and at the same time throws in one of the defenders. Whoever it is will be forced to lead a ♠ and eliminate your guess for the ♠Q or else give you a ruff-sluff, allowing you to ruff in dummy and discard a ♠ loser from your hand.

Among Bridge players you often hear about someone (usually Aunt Harriet) who is amazingly lucky at guessing the location of missing Queens.

Perhaps Aunt Harriet isn't that lucky after all, perhaps she just knows how to perform elimination plays.

Hopefully in the future you will be the one with the reputation!

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ —
♥ 9 6
♦ K Q J 10 8 7
♣ Q J 9 7 2

♠ 10 7 5 4 3
♥ A 3
♦ A 6 5
♣ K 6 3



♠ A K 8 6 2
♥ 10 5
♦ 4 3 2
♣ A 8 5

♠ Q J 9
♥ K Q J 8 7 4 2
♦ 9
♣ 10 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	4♥
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥K

When the bidding gets high in a hurry you sometimes have to guess what you can make. East plays 4♠. South leads the ♥K.

And it looks like you are too high. Assuming the trumps split 2-1, you still have one ♥ loser, two ♦ losers and one ♣ loser.

You win the ♥A and play a ♠ to your ♠K. North discards a ♦!

From bad to worse. Now you must add a ♠ loser to the four you already had. Are you finished?

No, never give up. South has a bunch of ♥s and 3 ♠s, so he cannot have many ♦s and ♣s. If you can eliminate those and then throw him in it should work to your advantage.

Play your ♠A, the ♦A and the ♣ A K. South follows to everything.

You've done all you can do. Now play the ♥10 to South's high ♥.

South has just won his side's first trick with the ♥J. He now plays the ♠Q, winning his side's second trick.

Now, South is still on lead, and he has nothing in his hand but good ♥s.

So he leads the ♥Q.

You **DO NOT RUFF**. Instead you discard a ♣ from dummy and a ♦ from your hand. South has now taken his side's third trick. He plays another good ♥, and you ruff in dummy and discard the last ♦ loser from your hand. You can now cross-ruff for the rest of the tricks.

Incredible isn't it.

You just wonder how many bridge players would have just conceded down 2 on this hand.

Not you or me, of course.

Board 3
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 10 9 3 ♥ 7 5 4 ♦ A J 6 ♣ Q 7 5	
♠ 6 ♥ K 8 2 ♦ K Q 10 3 2 ♣ 10 8 6 4		♠ 8 5 ♥ J 10 9 6 ♦ 9 8 7 4 ♣ J 9 2
	♠ K Q J 7 4 2 ♥ A Q 3 ♦ 5 ♣ A K 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

North's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points in support of ♠s. When you discover that the raise includes two Aces you bid the slam. South plays 6♠. West leads the ♦K, won by you with dummy's ♦A.

Is this a really easy elimination play showing up this late in the group? Or are you just getting better at seeing them? In any case, you should see that a successful ♥ finesse will land your contract, but you should also remember that there aren't many finesses working on these 25 deals.

So rather than finesse, eliminate! Pull trumps in two rounds, ending in dummy.

Ruff the ♦6, then play ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

So here you are in dummy. Do you finesse the ♥ now?

East plays low.

Of course not. You play the ♦J and discard a small ♥ from your hand. West wins his ♦Q (which his opening lead told you he held) and is end-played. He must lead a ♥ to your tenace or give you a ruff-sluff.

The answer to the question posed above is:

It is a pretty simple problem, but you are no doubt getting a lot better.

Board 4
North Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 9 7 4 ♥ 6 ♦ A Q 8 ♣ K Q J 7 5	
♠ K 6 ♥ A K J 10 5 2 ♦ K 5 3 ♣ A 10		♠ A 8 5 3 ♥ Q 7 4 ♦ 9 7 6 2 ♣ 8 3
	♠ J 10 2 ♥ 9 8 3 ♦ J 10 4 ♣ 9 6 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	Pass
Dbl	Pass	1♠	Pass
3♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♣K

East realizes that to make a takeout double, then jump in your own suit you must have a very good hand. So he bids the game. West plays 4♥. North leads the ♣K, which you take with the ♣A.

You have four losers. If you are thinking about leading toward your ♦K you are delusionary. North has the ♦A and you know it. Your best hope is to end-play North with the ♣10 and force him to break the ♦s.

Play one round of trumps with the ♥A. You can't play any more because you will need an entry to dummy for the elimination.

Next play ♠K, ♠A and ruff a ♠ high.

Lead a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q. North shows out. Play dummy's last ♠. South is now void, so if he ruffs you over-ruff. Otherwise you ruff with a small trump.

You are back in your hand.

Now throw North in (you hope!) with the ♣10.

Fortunately North has to take the ♣10. Since he has nothing left but ♣s and ♦s he must lead one or the other. A ♦ lead will give you a trick with your ♦K and a ♣ lead will allow you to ruff in dummy (South still has a ♣) and discard a ♦ from your hand.

Some problems are tougher than others, this being a tough one.

It was not a complete elimination since South still had a trump when you threw North in. However, it worked because North was out of both ♠s and ♥s.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K Q 6 3 2 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ 7 ♣ 7 6 4	
♠ 8 ♥ Q 10 8 4 2 ♦ A 9 5 2 ♣ A J 8	N W E S	♠ 4 ♥ K J 9 5 ♦ Q J 10 4 ♣ Q 10 9 2
	♠ J 10 9 7 5 ♥ 7 ♦ K 8 6 3 ♣ K 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦Q

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♦Q.

West plays the ♦2 and you the ♦7.

East continues with the ♦J.

West plays low and you ruff with the ♠Q.

Unless East is real beginner West will hold the ♦A so you should not try the ♦K on this trick. And when East continues with the ♦J you should again duck in dummy, ruffing with an honor in your hand.

The contract is in danger if West holds the ♣A because you would have three ♣ losers to go with the ♦ already lost. One really good possibility is that West now has the lone ♦A and you can set up dummy's ♦K with a ruff.

So play a small ♠ to dummy's ♠9, (pulling the two outstanding trumps), and ruff another ♦ with an honor, hoping the ♦A drops.

Too bad, the ♦A did not fall so dummy's ♦K is not a winner. But it will still prove to be useful.

Play the ♥A, then ruff a ♥ in dummy. Play a trump to your ♠A and ruff your last ♥.

You are in dummy, just where you want to be.

West plays the ♦A.

Play the ♦K, and when West plays the ♦A don't ruff but instead discard a ♣ from your hand. You knew all along that he held the ♦A.

West is end-played, forced to either break the ♣s and give you a ♣ trick, or give you a ruff-sluff.

This was the toughest hand so far and the end-play depended upon your correct reading that West must hold the ♦A.

It also depended upon the defenders not switching to ♣s at the second trick. If East had decided to switch to the ♣Q you would have had no chance at all.